Week 11 Teacher Guide: God's Created Order in the Assembly

The Obedience of Faith, Week 11 of 12. Closes Unit IV (God's House). Companion to Week11-GodsCreatedOrder.pptx. Scripture from the NET Bible.

Aim: Present the narrow, textually precise position on roles in the gathered church: the restriction concerns authoritative doctrinal teaching over men and the office attached to it, grounded in creation rather than culture, *alongside* the full breadth of ministry Scripture shows women exercising.

What this week must accomplish (and nothing more): the class leaves holding four words: *grounded, narrow, generous, for communion*, and having heard the "what Scripture does NOT restrict" material given **equal weight** to the restriction. If they leave thinking the lesson was only about what women can't do, the week failed, however sound the exegesis. The success test is whether a woman in the room who came in braced for diminishment leaves feeling that Scripture's honor of women's ministry was presented as fully and warmly as its limits.

Read this before anything else: this is the maximum-care week of the entire course. Every other tone warning in this course was a rehearsal for this one. The topic is personally wounding for some and sincerely disputed by others, and a mixed adult class will contain both. Non-negotiables:

1. **Lead with equality and dignity, structurally.** The brief's order is deliberate and pastoral: creation-equality *first*, then the restriction, then a full slide on what is *not* restricted, then honest ranking, then communion. Do not rearrange to "get to the restriction faster." The sequence *is* the pastoral care.
2. **Give the "not restricted" material equal airtime.** Segment 3 is half the lesson, not a footnote. If you rush it to protect time, you've taught a caricature. The deck weights it deliberately (four green boxes, its own slide).
3. **Concede the weak points out loud.** The scope-ranking table (slide 5) has a red row you must name as weak. Overclaiming is how this lesson loses credibility and wounds people. Say plainly where Scripture commands and where only early *practice* speaks.
4. **Protect everyone in the room.** Some women present may carry real wounds from bad teaching on this passage; some members hold egalitarian convictions sincerely and from love of the same Bible. Neither group is the enemy. Model "brothers and sisters, not opponents" and mean it.
5. **Invoke Week 5's permission again:** test the teacher, hard. A teacher who welcomes examination on *this* topic has already won most of the room's trust.

A note on the position taught. The deck argues the *narrow* complementarian reading (the one the user's own revised exegesis landed on): the restriction is specifically about the governing doctrinal-teaching office over the assembly, not about women's speech, gifting, or ministry generally. If your own conviction differs, the deck is still usable; the "what is not restricted," the honest-ranking, and

the "claim only what the text claims" segments are common ground across the spectrum, and the fairness ethic is the real curriculum here.

Presentation

Segment 1: The Storyline First (0:00–10:00 · Slide 2)

Open with the maximum-care tone-set (above), warmly, then go to creation before any restriction.

Genesis 1–2: equal, and ordered (first click). Man and woman *equally* bear God's image and *share* the mandate to rule (1:27–28): say this first and clearly; it is the foundation everything else sits on. Within that equality, an ordered partnership: Adam formed first, Eve made from him as "a helper corresponding to him" (2:18). Teach *ezer* ("helper") carefully: it is a *strong* word, used of God himself helping Israel (Ps 33:20; 121:2); it does not mean subordinate assistant. And note the timing: this differentiation exists *before the fall*; it is part of God's good design, not a result of sin or a curse to be undone.

Genesis 3: disorder through deception (second click). The serpent deceives Eve, Adam fails to guard, and the created harmony collapses into mistrust and domination (3:16's "he will dominate you" is a *description of the fall's damage*, not a prescription). Paul will appeal to this narrative, not to rank human worth, but to diagnose how deception unravels God's order.

1 Timothy 2:13–14 (third click). Read it plainly: "For Adam was formed first and then Eve. And Adam was not deceived, but the woman, because she was fully deceived, fell into transgression."

Read v.14 with care: the crucial guard (fourth click). **Spend real time here; it protects every woman in the room and proves you read carefully.** Two things v.14 does *not* say: (1) It is *not* a general claim that women are more gullible or intellectually inferior; it describes what happened in the *garden*, a specific event. (2) Scripture everywhere assigns *Adam* the primary responsibility for the fall: "sin entered the world through one man" (Rom 5:12), "in Adam all die" (1 Cor 15:22). Adam sinned *knowingly*, which Scripture treats as the graver failure, not the lesser. Say it out loud: any reading that turns v.14 into "women are inferior" has misread Paul and contradicted the rest of Scripture. Kill that misreading dead.

Transition: "Now the disputed text itself; notice how it *opens*."

Segment 2: The Text and Its Scope (10:00–24:00 · Slide 3)

"Let a woman learn" (first click). Start on the passage's *first move*, which is to *dignify*: "Let a woman learn in quietness with all submissiveness" (2:11). In much of the ancient world, women were not discipled as serious students of doctrine, and Paul *commands* it. Frame the entire text as, first, pro-woman-as-disciple. This reframing matters enormously for how the room hears everything after.

2:12 and "quietness" (second click). "I do not allow a woman to teach or exercise authority over a man. She must remain quiet." Teach *hēsychia* precisely: it means a settled, calm, non-disruptive posture; it is the *same word* used in 2:2 for the "peaceful and quiet life" we're to pray for, which nobody thinks means "mute." Precision here prevents overreach (it does not mean women can't speak, sing, pray, or answer in class).

The scope, read within the letter (third click). What *kind* of teaching is restricted? Read "teach" the way 1 Timothy itself uses it: as *authoritative doctrinal governance*: stopping false teaching (1:3), "command and teach these things" (4:11), guarding sound doctrine (6:2–3). And decisively, the *very next paragraph* (3:2) lists "able to teach" as an *overseer/elder* qualification. So the restriction concerns the governing teaching-and-authority role over the assembly, tied to the elder office, **not every word a woman might speak.** Name this explicitly as the *narrow* position.

Genesis, not Ephesus (fourth click). Why not read this as merely a local Ephesian fix? Because Paul grounds it in *creation* (v.13), and he *demonstrably knew how to give local reasons*: three chapters later he gives one: instruction to younger widows "so the adversary has no occasion for slander" (5:14). He had that tool available in 2:13 and reached past Ephesus to the garden instead. That choice is the strongest internal signal the reason is trans-local, not cultural (last week's grounding argument, now cashed). **Be fair:** note honestly that some careful readers take v.13 *itself* as a culturally-shaped argument, then give your reason for reading it as creational; don't pretend the other reading doesn't exist.

Transition: "Now, with equal weight, what Scripture does *not* restrict."

Segment 3: What Scripture Does NOT Restrict (24:00–34:00 · Slide 4)

This segment is half the lesson. Give it the same energy, warmth, and time as the restriction; more if anything. Deliver each item not as a grudging concession ("women may do these lesser things") but as *good news stated positively*: Scripture *plainly shows* women doing these, and *honors them by name* for it.

Four green boxes, one per click:

- **Pray and prophesy** (first click). 1 Corinthians 11:5 straightforwardly assumes women *do both* in the gathered church; Paul regulates the *manner* (head covering, in that context), not the *permission*. This is significant: prophecy is public, Spirit-given, authoritative-in-content speech, and women exercised it in the assembly.
- **Labor in the gospel** (second click). Euodia and Syntyche "struggled *beside* me in the gospel" (Phil 4:2–3); Romans 16 names roughly ten women as coworkers Paul honors; his ministry ran *on* the labor of women. Read a few names aloud.
- **Serve** (third click). Phoebe is "a *diakonos* of the church at Cenchrea" (Rom 16:1), commended and evidently entrusted to carry the Roman letter itself. A recognized servant-office.
- **Teach in fitting settings** (fourth click). Titus 2:3–5 *commands* older women to teach younger women; Priscilla (with Aquila) "explained the way of God more accurately" to Apollos (Acts

18:26). So *teaching per se* is not the issue; the governing assembly office is. Women teach women and children; privately, alongside her husband, they can teach a man.

Holding 11:5 and 14:34 together (fifth click). Address the apparent contradiction head-on rather than hoping no one notices. Prophecy and authoritative teaching are *different functions*. Note 14:29: "the others should *weigh/evaluate*" what the prophets say. A woman may *prophesy* (11:5); the restriction touches the authoritative *weighing* of doctrine that governs the assembly. Both texts stand; neither is explained away. (This is the Week 8 "hold both texts" care applied to the hardest pair in the New Testament.)

Transition: "So let's be precise and honest about what rests on *what*."

Segment 4: Claim Only What the Text Claims (34:00–42:00 · Slide 5)

The scope-ranking table appears whole, color-coded by strength. **This slide is the ethical heart of the week**: walk it top to bottom and let the honesty do its work.

- **Elder/Overseer office = male** (green, *strongest*): rests on explicit male qualifications (1 Tim 3:2 "the husband of one wife"; Titus 1:6).
- **No governing doctrinal teaching over men** (green, *strong*): rests on 1 Tim 2:12 with the creation reason in v.13.
- **No authoritative weighing of prophecy** (gold, *moderate*): rests on 1 Cor 14:29–35 read in context.
- **Women not baptizing / not presiding** (red, *weak; say so!*): rests on *early-church practice*, not on any New Testament command.

Say the red row out loud as weak. This is the single most credibility-building move of the week: "I will not claim Scripture *forbids* a woman baptizing, because it doesn't. The early church did restrict it; that's *testimony to their practice*, not a *command of the text*, and I'll hold it loosely and label it honestly." Conceding this openly is exactly what earns the room's trust for the strong rows. Overclaiming a weak point discredits the strong ones; that's the ethic (first click after the table: the honesty principle).

Equality of being, difference of function (second click). The anchor is the Trinity: "the head of Christ is God" (1 Cor 11:3). The Son is *fully God*, equal in being and of one essence with the Father, *and* joyfully ordered to the Father's will (John 5:19; Phil 2). So functional order does *not* imply lesser worth; the clearest case in the universe proves it. **Handle gently and don't wade into the eternal-subordination-of-the-Son controversy**; that's a live intramural debate you don't need. Just the plain point: order and equal worth coexist, demonstrably.

Transition: "So what is all of this *for*?"

Segments 5–6: Purpose and Discussion (42:00–57:00 · Slide 6)

Purpose (first click). **Do not skip this even if you're tight on time: it's the pastoral resolution of the whole hour.** The goal is not power, control, or restriction for its own sake. The church is God's *household* (1 Tim 3:15): a family, a body, a bride. Ordered *love*, not corporate hierarchy; every member vital and indispensable (1 Cor 12). The assembly *rehearses restored creation*: differentiated roles serving one communion under Christ. Reframe the entire hour, at its end, from *restriction* to *ordered love*.

Q1: "How does 'let a woman learn' reframe the passage? And why does grounding matter?" Two parts. First: the passage *opens* by making the woman a disciple, reframing the whole text as pro-discipleship rather than anti-woman. Second: culture-vs-creation grounding (last week's tool) is what decides whether a text is a *waypoint* culture has moved beyond or a *pattern* rooted in how God made us. Let both surface.

Q2: "Where must WE be careful to claim only what the text claims? Where have you seen this handled badly, in either direction?" The humility question, and note "either direction" is load-bearing: *overclaiming* (making the text about women's worth, or forbidding what Scripture permits) and *underclaiming* (explaining away the plain restriction) are *both* errors. Invite honest examples gently and in the first person; **do not permit naming absent people or specific churches.** Keep it about the handling, not the handlers.

Facilitation, extra care. This is the discussion most likely to become personal or heated in the whole course. Move slowly. If someone shares a wound, honor it before you continue. If it heats up, return to two anchors: the *text* ("what does it actually say?") and the *relationship* ("we're brothers and sisters, not opponents"). Read the ground-rule line on the slide aloud if needed. No one "wins." The stated success condition: if the class leaves more careful with Scripture and gentler with each other, the lesson worked.

The close (slide 7, ~2 min). Next week is the finale. Reading: Matthew 28:16–20 (the Commission: find "obey") and Hebrews 5:11–6:3 (the course's home passage: "ought to be teachers by this time"). Both tie the whole course together. Preview Week 12 as the landing. Carry sentence: four beats: *grounded, narrow, generous, for communion*, said together. Then close *deliberately* on "let a woman learn": **end where the passage begins, on dignity, not on restriction.** Dismiss warmly and unhurried; linger if people want to talk. The willingness to stay and listen after this particular lesson is itself pastoral care.

Answers to Questions You May Get

(This week especially, "I don't know; let's look" is a fine and trust-building answer. Better to under-claim than to bluff on contested ground.)

"Isn't this just baptizing an outdated patriarchal culture, the trajectory argument from last week?" It's the honest heart of the disagreement, so honor it. The reason it isn't (on the narrow reading taught here) is *where Paul grounds it*: not in Ephesian custom but in creation (2:13), and he demonstrably *could* have given a cultural reason and didn't (5:14). Slavery had no creation grounding, so its cultural anchor could drag; this has one. **But be fair and say it:** thoughtful, Bible-loving people weigh that grounding differently; some read 2:13 as itself a culturally-framed argument. This is genuinely contested exegesis, held with conviction *and* humility, not a settled proof. If someone lands differently after honest study of the text, they're not being unfaithful.

"You said women prophesied publicly (1 Cor 11:5). How is prophesying to the church not 'teaching with authority'?" Because Scripture itself distinguishes them. Prophecy is *reporting* what the Spirit prompts; it is then *submitted to evaluation*: "let the others weigh it" (14:29). Teaching-with-authority is the *governing* function that *does* the evaluating and defines doctrine for the assembly. A prophet delivers; the governing teacher/elder adjudicates. That's why a woman can prophesy (11:5) while the authoritative doctrinal-governance role is restricted (2:12): two different functions, both preserved. Where exactly the line falls in practice is debated, and reasonable people draw it in somewhat different places.

"Doesn't 'the husband of one wife' for elders (1 Tim 3:2) just assume the culture's typical case, not require maleness?" A real argument, and worth stating fairly. The response: the qualification lists are detailed and deliberate, the elder role is precisely the governing-teaching function 2:12 addresses, and the two passages sit in the same short letter reinforcing each other, so the maleness reads as intended rather than incidental. But this is exactly the kind of point where you should say "here's why I read it this way, and here's the counter-reading" rather than pronounce. It's on the *strong* row of the ranking, not the *incontestable* row.

"Where does this leave a gifted woman who clearly could teach better than most of the men?" Answer gently and without defensiveness, because it's often asked from real pain. Gifting is real, God-given, and meant to be *used*: Scripture shows women teaching women, children, and privately; laboring in the gospel; prophesying; serving; and shaping the church profoundly (Rom 16). The restriction is *narrow* (one governing office), not a verdict on a woman's competence, intelligence, or spiritual depth, which may exceed any man's in the room. And competence was never the basis of the restriction (it's grounded in creation order, not ability), just as competence isn't why *most men* are also not elders. The question is role, not worth or gift.

"The early church had deaconesses and women who led; hasn't the church been more restrictive than the Bible?" Quite possibly, in places, and this is where the honest-ranking table pays off. The New Testament shows women as serving (Phoebe), prophets, and gospel coworkers, and later church practice sometimes narrowed that further than the text requires (and the baptizing/presiding restrictions rest on *practice*, not command). A faithful reading may well *expand* women's recognized ministry back toward the biblical breadth while still holding the narrow restriction the text grounds in creation. "More careful with Scripture" cuts both ways: against overclaiming *and* against traditions that shrank what God permits.

"Why would a good God restrict any role by sex at all; isn't that just unfair?" Reframe from fairness-as-sameness to the household/communion vision (the purpose slide). Difference of role is not a ranking of worth: the Son is equal to the Father and ordered to him (1 Cor 11:3); no one

calls *that* unfair. In God's household, order exists *for* communion, love, and the flourishing of the whole body, not for the elevation of some over others. The question Scripture presses isn't "did I get the role I wanted?" but "will I serve where I'm placed, for the good of the family?" That is, after all, the *obedience of faith* the whole course is about.

Prep Checklist

- [ ] Read 1 Timothy 2:8–3:7 as one flow: 2:11–15 and the elder qualifications must be seen together
- [ ] Read 1 Corinthians 11:2–16 and 14:26–40 side by side; be ready to hold 11:5 and 14:34 without flinching
- [ ] Read Romans 16 and count the women Paul commends: have two or three names ready to speak aloud
- [ ] Look up *ezer* (Gen 2:18) and *hēsychia* (1 Tim 2:11–12; cf. 2:2) so you can teach both precisely
- [ ] Decide, in advance, exactly how you'll say the red "weak: say so" row out loud (rehearse the concession)
- [ ] Reread the maximum-care mandate above the morning you teach; plan to linger afterward
- [ ] Print/post next week's reading with both flags ("obey" in the Commission; "ought to be teachers")

If You Run Long

Cut in this order: compress the Genesis 3 detail on slide 2 (keep the v.14 guard; never cut that); trim the scope-from-within-the-letter citations on slide 3 to 4:11 and 3:2 (the two load-bearing ones); shorten the Trinity-anchor unpacking on slide 5 (state the plain point, skip the nuance). **Never cut:** the equality-first opening, the v.14 "what it does not say" guard, *any* of the four "not restricted" boxes (cutting them re-caricatures the lesson; cut elsewhere first), the red "weak: say so" row, or the communion-purpose slide. If discussion must shrink, keep Q2 (the "claim only what the text claims, in either direction" humility question is the week's ethical take-home); protect a few minutes for it; a rushed discussion on *this* topic is worse than a slightly shortened lecture.